Chapter 3

Art as a Social Work
Amy Morales Lara

Learning Outcome

By the end of this chapter, you will understand Amy Morales Lara's vision of integrating creative arts with social work and analyse how art functions as a tool for healing, storytelling, and community empowerment. Key ideas such as empathy, compassion, and curiosity are discussed. You will evaluate how art fosters resilience and social change.

Author bio

Amy Morales Lara is a daughter of immigrant parents and a native of Bronx in New York, she is pursuing a Master of Social Work degree from the Silberman School of Social Work. Amy is also a Cabrini-Hunter clinical fellow, published playwright, and emerging singer-songwriter. Amy is passionate about combining her interests in creative arts and mental health, believing their synergy can bring healing and liberation to others. Amy Morales Lara discusses her project "Art as Social Work," and how she was deeply moved and touched by the struggles and strengths of the people of the Bronx, how it influenced their art, and how it aided in processing trauma. She believes that art is accessible to everyone and emphasizes on qualities like empathy and curiosity. She believes that, if one is passionate about what they are doing, they will surely find ways to contribute to the betterment of society. Life, she believes is an opportunity; an opportunity to serve those around us, the community, the society, and the world in general.

Transcript

Lost. Part of the reason I feel lost is because I feel like I don't know what I'm doing. I'm a current grad student pursuing a degree in social work. And the questions that I've been asking myself are quite as essential. May be some of you have asked yourselves some of the same things. The questions that I have been asking are these: Who do I want to become? And what do I want to do with my life? The way I've dealt with these questions is by looking to people that inspire me on the path that I'm on. If there's anything I want to do with my life, it is to be the helper that Mr. Roger, beloved childhood icon, talks about in an interview, when he says "I would see scary things on the news and my mother would say to look for the helpers, you will always find people who are helping." For those who don't know, Mr. Rogers is a legend, he was a kind and friendly man in a vibrant red sweater that told me that my feelings mattered. My mother would play his program at home and I always looked forward to watching it. What I thought was so special about what Mr. Rogers was doing is how he did it, because he used so many creative things. He used puppets, TV broadcasting, and even music. He

used it to tell positive messages to children about their emotions, how they were feeling, and about the world around them.

As I got into my adulthood, I realized that I wanted to do something very similar. I wanted to be a helper, and I wanted to use the creative arts to do it. Now I want to clarify what I think a helper is. A helper isn't somebody that rescues someone from their problems or presents themselves as a solution for them. A helper is someone who is willing to partner with someone in their own process of self development and growth. I want to be that kind of helper, and I, again, want to use the creative arts to do it. But the question that I have been asking myself as a social work student is this: How do I combine my love for helping others in social work with the creative arts? Now I want to start off by defining what social work and art are. Social work can be defined in many ways. But the way that I would simply put it is this: Social work is a practice-based discipline that promotes social change. It also empowers and collaborates with individuals and communities in order to bring about equitable outcomes, provide support, and also access to care. My definition of art is also something that is personal. Art is another thing that can be defined in many ways. But the way I would define it is this: Art is a creative expression, or a form of creative expression, that can help you tell a story. So it can be poetry, dancing, or even knitting. If it's something that is a creative form of expression and something that can help you tell a story, I consider it to be art. My medium of choice has always been music. Music has been such an important part of my life, and it's something I hold near and dear to my heart. For most of my youth and adolescence, I was a part of a professional children's choir, and now I'm a singer-songwriter. Music was something I felt like helped me challenge a lot of negative narratives I had about myself. And it helped me reclaim who I was. Singing songs and sharing songs that I've written with people who are willing to listen showed me that I was not the sum of my anxious thoughts, and that I was capable of something bigger than myself. Whenever I could write a song and people resonated with it, I felt like I was establishing a connection. It would be something that I would continue to carry with me into the future. I graduated college with a degree in music industry and social work, which is not a surprise because music is something that, again, is really important to me.

With my degree I took a lot of jobs that was associated with music. I had some jobs working for music collectives, and I even performed and did a lot of art programming for a bunch of community centers in Bronx. The way I saw people connect and engage with music and the arts was a beautiful experience, because, again, it showed me the value of why it's so important to be creative. After program hours, I saw students lingering to write songs together and record on the audio set-up that we had. But then I started to think about my future again. I started to ask myself: “Hmmm… what do I want to be ten years from now? How can I secure a future and make sure that I can expand my professional experience?” I wanted to keep my options open, so I wanted to explore what was out there. I eventually took a job as a research coordinator at a clinic, where I interviewed families for all of the research projects we had going on at the time. My favorite part about that job was learning about families and hearing their stories. It was a beautiful thing to be a part of their process for that short moment, and I loved hearing about their everyday life and who they were. I realized I was a people-centered person, and I wanted to pursue a career that emphasized that. So I took my people-centered brain to a place that made so much sense, and I ended up in social work school.

Enrolling in my program was a surreal experience for me. I was sitting in front of my computer in the middle of the pandemic, and I was so nervous because I didn't know what to expect. I didn't even know if I was in the right place. I was just doing what I felt like I needed to do to connect the puzzle pieces of my life. Remember thinking about creative arts and also helping others. My professor came on and began to ask us what we hope to accomplish in our career. I was just honest. I told her I want to try to find a way to combine the creative arts and social work. I am not even sure if that's possible. But I wanted to see if I can try, so I'm here to learn. With a knowing smile, my professor looked at me and said, “In many ways, many social workers are also frustrated artists.” That phrase rocked my world because it made me feel like maybe I was in the right place. Maybe this is where I needed to be, and what I needed to explore. I am a frustrated artist. I was frustrated by the idea that I had to de-prioritize art in order to secure my future. And it wasn't something that felt right to me. And although I was pursuing something else, I always felt the ringing of the creative arts in my ear, and I always felt music resonating in my soul, and I knew that wherever I went, I was going to bring it with me. What my professor said really changed my perspective because it reminded me of perhaps this intersection isn't impossible. I just needed to be courageous enough to take that chance. In social work practice, we're constantly challenged to question narratives and engage with the world around us with empathetic curiosity. I am learning so much about social work and how it works and what we need to know in order to provide care for others. I learned about clinical work with individuals and families, community organizing and advocacy, just to name a few things, and then I began to see the puzzle pieces kind of set together. Oh, I thought art exists in a lot of these spaces as well. For example, in clinical spaces, art therapy is seen as a valuable intervention for people that might be struggling with anxiety or depression. For community organizing, community mural projects have been a way for community organizations, to have people invest in their communities and develop relationships with their neighbors. And lastly, art is also very present in advocacy. Have you seen how creative people are with their picket signs? They use beautiful images and words to get their point across, in a way that I believe is quite artistic, if you ask me. It was encouraging to see this connection in this intersection because, again, it reminded me that perhaps my path isn't necessarily all that wrong or impossible. I began to see and learn more about social work and what it means, and seeing how art can play a role in that really inspired me.

During my social work program, I did a year-long project where we were supposed to use community resources, curiosity, and of course, empathy, to learn about communities that we hope to work with. I did my project on a place that I call ‘home’ and is close to my heart: the Bronx. I wanted to explore the narratives of the Bronx and how art can help us not only understand the context, but also see how we can see things a little differently. I called my magazine "Renaissance Rhythm & Resistance: How The Arts Can Help Heal The Narratives of The Bronx.” For those of you who don't know, the Bronx doesn't always get a good rap. It's one of the poorest counties in New York state and a lot of people say that it doesn't have a good reputation of being a safe and happy place to live. But we often forget that the Bronx had a meaningful art renaissance that brought about things that changed the world as we know it. Things like hip-hop, salsa, break dancing, graffiti, and that's just a few things that have been ground-breaking developments that have been cultivated in our very city. I often found that the Bronx was characterized by its struggle, but it wasn't emphasized for its strengths. Why are we not centering the strengths that we see in our home and in our communities, and why is that not the case for the Bronx? I use this project as an opportunity to see how we can use art to challenge narratives that we hear and explore them a bit further. I thought

interviewing Bronx artists was a great place to start. Interviewing process was amazing. I loved learning about their stories and hearing who they were. I got to interview a digital artist in furniture rehabilitator who told me about how their art challenges notions of classes, furniture affordability, as she found that Bronx members and Bronx families that she worked with couldn't afford nice furniture. I also interviewed a hip-hop artist who used hip-hop and rap to explore his identity as a black man, and also coming from an immigrant family. I also interviewed a fantastic visual artist, who also used his illustrations and gallery work to explore injustice, racism, and other meaningful topics to the general populace. It was a wonderful thing to see how growing up in the Bronx, living in this context, and also listening to how they were travelling through their journey, because it taught me, again, how wonderful it was to hear how the strengths and their struggles were things that brought them forward. It was amazing to hear how the barriers and the systemic struggles they were dealing with, helped them make beautiful art. It also helped them process trauma that not only helped them change their perspective of the world and who they were, but it also influenced them to create things that they can pass on to future generations. Being a part of this project, and doing this initially made my soul sing, because I got to see the intersections of my two loves meet. It was wonderful to walk with people in their stories and shortly be a part of it during its retelling. To hear the narratives being challenged and knowing that there's more to the story than what we hear. It was also so profound because it brought me back to my childhood and why I loved being a part of the Bronx being growing up here. It reminded me of the sound of boom boxes of the summer black boys that were the rhythm and pulse of my city. It reminded me of the several art galleries we had on alleyways and the side of businesses that told stories of our culture, our communal context, and our vivid imagination. It reminded me that the Bronx is not only breathing with art, but it is breathing with healing and transformation. This was my social brain at work. My social work brain was excited to see all of these things come about and, I was so overwhelmed by the opportunity to see part of my dream for a short moment become reality. I was able to emphasize and understand some of the systemic barriers these people experienced. But I was also able to walk with them in their stories, and allow them to be the center and the experts of their own experience. And it's something I think that I will carry with me for the rest of my career, even if it's just started. I've learned so much about what social work is and who I am becoming, and I believe I'm not where I've started, but I know that I have a lot to learn and I'm still trying to figure out who I want to be in the world. But I know that empathy, compassion, and curiosity have brought me where I am today.

I am still lost. But I do believe that I'm also finding my way and leaning into that discomfort of not knowing what's coming next. Now I want to point it back to you. Aren't you lost? Aren't you trying to figure out what you want to be? And who you want to become? Maybe you're struggling with your next professional step in life, maybe you're struggling with a relationship transition that isn't going well. Whatever it is, perhaps it's time to pursue your next step creatively. Can taking on an artist endeavor help you figure out how you feel? Be curious about yourself and what's going on inside of you and how you relate to community contexts around you? Can participating in a communal context help you combat things like loneliness and help you understand who your neighbors are and who they claim to be?

I believe that art is accessible to everyone, and you don't necessarily need to even be good at something to be curious about what it can do for you. I think it can be really intimidating to enter an art space. But just know that the goal isn't perfection. It's courageousness, it's bravery, and it's openness. To be curious about what can come

about, and to also understand that you can become a new person, just by trying new things. And for those who are in more traditional or corporate spaces, just know that art is good for you too. There was a study done with staffing nurses where they were put in a series of art activities for a period of time. After the weeks were over, it was observed that many of the nursing staff experienced improved levels of general well-being and mental health, reduced levels of stress and fatigue. And they even said that it increased the sense of community at their job. Seventy-five percent of those participants even said that they might consider participating in art activities for the future.

New things can be scary, but that doesn't mean that they're impossible. So, for those out there, who want to tap into something creatively to see where it leads you, I invite you to be open to the process of the unknown, and allowing yourself to be unraveled by the things you discover about yourself and your community. Maybe it can even give you a new sense of purpose, and show you who you can become, and how to be with the people better. The last question I want to end with is this: How can you walk with people in their stories? How can you tap into that empathetic curiosity that I mentioned before, even if this isn't something that you're ready to pursue yet? Just know that you don't even need to be an artist or a social worker to lean into things like compassion, empathy and curiosity. Those are also accessible to everyone. And by leaning into these principles and concepts, we can all be helpers. Thank you.

Summary

Defining the Synergy: Art and Social Work

In the TED talk ‘Art as a Social Work,’ Amy Morales Lara, a current graduate student from New York pursuing a Master of Social Work, frames her presentation around an essential question: how to combine the love for helping others through social work with the creative arts? She provides clear definitions for both disciplines, which is crucial for understanding their intersection:

- **Social Work**: Defined simply as a practice-based discipline that promotes social change. It empowers and collaborates with individuals and communities to bring about equitable outcomes, provide support, and ensure access to care.
- **Art**: Defined personally by Lara as a creative expression that helps one tell a story, which could be through poetry, dancing, or even knitting. Music is her medium of choice, which helped her challenge negative self-narratives and reclaim her identity.

Lara’s pursuit of this intersection was validated by a professor who stated, "In many ways, many social workers are also frustrated artists". This realization changed her perspective, affirming that her path was not impossible and that she needed only to be courageous enough to explore it.

The Role of the Helper

Lara was inspired to become a "helper," recalling the advice of childhood icon Mr. Rogers. Mr. Rogers himself effectively used creative mediums like puppets, music, and TV broadcasting to send positive messages to children.

Lara clarifies that a helper is not someone who rescues others or presents a solution. Rather, a helper partners with an individual in their process of self-development and growth. She emphasizes that to effectively partner with others in social work, three qualities are essential: empathy, compassion, and curiosity.

Lara's own experience as a research coordinator, where she interviewed families, confirmed her path, as she enjoyed being "people-centered" and listening to their stories and everyday life. This active engagement and people-centered focus is key to her approach.

Application of Art in Social Work

Lara discovered that the intersection of art and social work is already existing, finding examples across various domains of practice:

- **Clinical Spaces:** Art therapy is utilized as a valuable intervention for individuals struggling with conditions like anxiety or depression.
- **Community Organizing:** Community mural projects encourage people to invest in their neighborhoods and develop relationships with their neighbors.
- **Advocacy:** Art plays a role in activism, as creative picket signs utilize "beautiful images and words to get their point across".

The Bronx Project

Lara applied these concepts in a year-long project focused on her home community in the Bronx, New York. While the Bronx is often "characterized by its struggle" and poor reputation, Lara emphasized its strengths, such as its meaningful art renaissance that birthed global phenomena like hip-hop, salsa, and graffiti.

By interviewing Bronx artists, Lara learned how art helped them process trauma, challenge systemic barriers (like class and racism), and explore identity. The systemic struggles the artists dealt with were paradoxically things that helped them make beautiful art, influencing future generations. This experience reinforced her belief that the Bronx is "breathing with healing and transformation".

Conclusion

Lara concludes by inviting the audience to pursue their next steps creatively, acknowledging that the goal of entering an art space is <u>not perfection, but courageousness, bravery, and openness.</u> Research supports this, as studies show art activities improve general well-being, reduce stress, and increase community among professionals, such as staffing nurses. By leaning into the accessible principles of compassion, empathy, and curiosity, Lara argues, anyone can embody the role of a helper.

Multiple Choice Questions

1. How does Amy Morales Lara personally define art in the context of her discussion?

A. A skill that requires a professional certification.
B. A practice-based discipline that promotes social change.
C. A form of creative expression that can help you tell a story.
D. Only specialized creative fields like painting and sculpture.

2. According to Amy Morales Lara, what is the primary role of a "helper" in the context of social work?
   A. To rescue someone from their problems and provide definitive solutions.
   B. To manage equitable outcomes and access to care for a community.
   C. To partner with someone in their own process of self-development and growth.
   D. To challenge negative self-narratives through music and songwriting.
3. What phrase, spoken by her professor, validated Amy Morales Lara's idea of combining creative arts and social work?
   A. "The intersection is not impossible, only requires courage."
   B. "In many ways, many social workers are also frustrated artists."
   C. "Art is accessible to everyone, regardless of skill level."
   D. "You must lean into the principles of compassion, empathy, and curiosity."
4. Amy Morales Lara notes that art is present in advocacy. What specific example does she cite to show how creative people use art in advocacy?
   A. Creating digital art to explore identity and injustice.
   B. Organizing community mural projects.
   C. Utilizing beautiful images and words on picket signs.
   D. Implementing art therapy for anxiety and depression.
5. Amy Morales Lara highlights that the Bronx had a meaningful art renaissance that brought about things that changed the world as we know it. Name any two of the few things she mentions that have been ground-breaking developments that have been cultivated in the Bronx:
   A. Abstract painting and modern poetry.
   B. Jazz and classical music theory.
   C. Hip-hop and salsa.
   D. Film-making and traditional theater.
6. When encouraging the audience to enter an art space, what key quality does Amy Morales Lara explicitly state is not the goal?
   A. Courageousness.
   B. Openness.
   C. Bravery.
   D. Perfection.
7. In "Art as Social Work," Amy Morales Lara likely emphasizes the role of art in:
   A. Generating profit
   B. Providing entertainment
   C. Facilitating healing and liberation
   D. Creating political propaganda
8. How does Amy Morales Lara view the intersection of art and social work?
   A. As two unrelated fields
   B. As a way to monetize creative talents
   C. As a powerful tool for community building and emotional support
   D. As a form of traditional therapy

Answer keys:
1. C ; 2. C ; 3. B ; 4. C ; 5. C ; 6. D ; 7. C ; 8. C

Short Answer Questions

1. How does Amy Morales Lara simply define social work, focusing on its practice-based nature?
2. Lara clarifies that a helper is not someone who rescues others. Instead, what action is a helper willing to take in a person's process of self-development and growth?
3. What specific phrase, shared by her professor, "rocked [Amy Morales Lara's] world" and inspired her to combine her passion for creative arts with social work?
4. What were her long-term goals as a social worker and a creative artist?
5. Who inspired her to take up her role as a social worker?
6. How did Lara believe that her background and experiences will help her connect with and support the diverse youth of the Bronx?

Essay Questions

5. What advice does she give to other aspiring social workers and artists who want to combine their passions to help their communities?
6. How can art be utilized in social work, particularly in marginalized communities?
7. Discuss the therapeutic benefits of creative expression and how it can serve as a non-verbal means of processing trauma and building resilience.

Activities for Listening

1. Listen to the following podcast on YouTube by scanning the provided QR code. Focus on the talk first and then the given subtitles as well to check your comprehension level.
2. Listen to the following video by the National Geographic on Onam celebrations in Kerala and see if you can understand it entirely.
3. Pair up with a partner where one person shares a story or experience while the other listens without interrupting. Afterwards, the listener summarises the story to ensure they have understood it correctly. Then, repeat the same exercise with the other person.